MODULE 35 · DOMAIN 3 - BUSINESS ENVIRONMENT

Impediments and issues

Risk or issue, surfacing blockers, evaluating and prioritising them, choosing an intervention, workarounds, and continual reassessment.

DOMAIN III - Business Environment EXAM WEIGHT 26% MODULE 35 of 49

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An issue is happening **now**. Clear the path quickly, at the right level, then find out why.

Risk or issue?

RISK

Might happen

- An uncertain future event
- Recorded in the risk register
- Managed with a planned response
- Can be a threat or an opportunity

ISSUE

Is happening

- A current problem or condition
- Recorded in the issue log
- Resolved, or worked around
- Needs action now

THE TIEBREAKER

When an identified risk occurs, it becomes an issue. Use its planned response first.

Impediments, obstacles and blockers

KIND	EXAMPLES
Waiting on others	An approval, a decision, another team's deliverable
Tools and environments	A test environment down, missing access or licences
Information	Unclear requirements, a missing answer from a stakeholder
People	A key person unavailable, a skills gap
Organisational	A policy, process or rule slowing the work

ON THE EXAM

Most impediments are outside the team's control. That is why removing them is a leader's job.

Handling an impediment

01
Surface
Make it visible, early.

02
Evaluate
What does it block, and how much does that matter?

03
Prioritise
Highlight the ones that matter most.

04
Intervene
Choose and apply a strategy.

05
Reassess
Check it is really cleared; review the rest.

ON THE EXAM

This is the outline's enablers in order: evaluate, prioritise and highlight, intervene, reassess.

Surfacing impediments early

- The **daily coordination meeting** asks directly: is anything in your way?
- Mark blocked items visibly on the **board**, with how long they have been blocked.
- Keep an **issue log** for problems beyond a single day or a single team.
- People raise blockers only when it is **safe** to admit being stuck.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> A blocker hidden for three days costs three days. Make raising it normal and safe.

Evaluating impact and prioritising

- Is it on the **critical path**, or does it threaten the **sprint or release goal**?
- How much work, and how many people, does it block?
- What does each day of delay cost?
- Highlight the top items to those who can act: the team, the sponsor, other managers.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> The outline asks you to prioritise and highlight. Fix what blocks the goal first, not what was raised first.

The issue log

FIELD	PURPOSE
Description and date raised	What the issue is, and since when
Impact and priority	What it affects, and how urgent it is
Owner	One named person responsible for resolving it
Actions and due date	What will be done, and by when
Status and resolution	Open, in progress, resolved, and how

ON THE EXAM

Every issue has one owner and a due date. An issue owned by 'the team' is owned by nobody.

Intervention strategies

STRATEGY	WHEN IT FITS
Team resolves it	The team has the skills and authority; the leader supports
Leader removes it	The blocker sits outside the team, within the leader's reach
Negotiate	Another team or manager controls what is needed
Workaround	An unplanned problem needs a fast, temporary fix
Escalate	Resolution needs authority beyond the project manager's
Accept and re-plan	It cannot be removed; adjust the plan and inform stakeholders

ON THE EXAM

The outline asks you to determine and apply an intervention strategy. Match it to where the blocker sits.

Planned response or workaround?

PLANNED RISK RESPONSE

Prepared in advance

- For an identified risk
- Written in the risk register
- Often funded from contingency
- Use it first when the risk occurs

WORKAROUND

Improvised now

- For an unplanned problem
- No response existed
- Fast and temporary
- Log it, then fix the root cause

THE TIEBREAKER

Risk occurred and a response exists: use it. Nothing was planned: work around it, then learn.

When a risk becomes an issue

- Check the **risk register**: was this risk identified, with a response planned?
- If yes, **implement the planned response**, and its contingency if funded.
- Move it to the issue log, and update the risk register: this risk has occurred.
- Check for **secondary risks** the response itself creates.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> 'The risk has occurred. What next?' Consult the register and apply the planned response.

Collaborating to resolve issues

- The outline asks you to **collaborate with relevant stakeholders** on the approach to resolve issues.
- Bring in the people who can actually resolve it, and those it affects.
- Agree the approach together, rather than imposing one.
- Keep affected stakeholders informed until it is closed.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Issues are resolved with the people who hold the key, not around them.

Reassessing continually, and learning

- The outline asks you to **reassess continually** that impediments are being addressed.
- Review open issues on a rhythm: daily for blockers, weekly for the issue log.
- Watch **ageing**: an issue open for weeks with no progress needs a new strategy or escalation.
- After resolution, find the **root cause** and capture the lesson, so it does not recur.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> An issue log full of old, ownerless items is not issue management. Review, act, close, learn.

Project Lantern: issues in practice

- The risk register had foreseen a kiosk shipping delay; the planned response, a loan kiosk, was used at once.
- An unforeseen network outage at clinic four: a mobile router workaround, logged, then a root-cause fix.
- The app team was blocked by a firewall change; the project manager went to the security lead that day.
- The issue log is reviewed weekly; anything open over two weeks goes to the sponsor.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Planned response for a foreseen risk; workaround for a surprise; leader removes the external blocker; ageing rule.

Scenario signals and the move

THE SCENARIO SAYS	THE MOVE
An identified risk has occurred	Consult the register; apply the planned response
An unforeseen problem stops work	Workaround; log it; inform; fix the root cause
Team blocked by another department	Leader engages that department; escalate if needed
Several issues, limited capacity	Prioritise by impact on the goal or critical path
An old, ownerless issue log	Review, assign owners and dates, close or escalate
Someone hid a blocker for days	Help now; build safety to raise blockers early

ON THE EXAM

Planned response if it exists; workaround if not; the leader removes what the team cannot.

> The risk register identified that the company's own test laboratory might be unavailable during product testing. The planned response was to rent an external laboratory, funded from contingency.
>
> The internal laboratory has just been closed for three weeks for repairs.

What should the project manager do next?

A Implement the planned response and rent the external laboratory, then update the risk register and issue log.

B Create a new plan for testing, since the situation has changed.

C Escalate the closure to the sponsor for a decision.

D Record the event in the lessons learned register.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do next?

A Apply the planned response; update records.
The risk was foreseen and a funded response exists. Use it.

B Make a new plan.
Throws away the response prepared for exactly this.

C Escalate to the sponsor.
The response is already planned and funded, within the PM's authority.

D Lessons learned.
Useful later, but it does nothing to keep testing going.

THE SIGNAL

An identified risk has occurred and its response is planned: apply it. That is what planning was for.

> A shared build server fails, stopping three developers from deploying their work. Nothing in the risk register covers this.
>
> The infrastructure team says a permanent fix will take two days.

What should the project manager do?

A Wait for the infrastructure team's permanent fix.

B Look for the planned response in the risk register.

C Agree a workaround with the team, log the issue, inform affected stakeholders, and follow up on the root cause.

D Escalate the failure to the sponsor immediately.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Wait two days.

Three developers idle for two days when a workaround may exist.

B Check the risk register.

The question says nothing there covers it. There is no planned response.

C Workaround, log, inform, root cause.

An unplanned issue: keep work flowing now, then fix it properly.

D Escalate immediately.

A two-day infrastructure fault is within normal project management.

THE SIGNAL

No planned response exists: work around it, log it, inform people, then fix the cause.

> An agile team has been blocked for three days, waiting for the corporate security team to open a firewall port. The request is sitting in the security team's general queue.
>
> The sprint goal is now at risk.

What should the project leader do?

A Let the developers disable the firewall on their test machines to keep working.

B Wait for the security team to reach the request in its queue.

C Raise the delay at the next sprint retrospective.

D Contact the security team lead directly to resolve it, escalating if needed, and keep the blocker visible.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project leader do?

A Disable the firewall.

Breaches security policy. A workaround that creates a compliance problem.

B Wait in the queue.

Three days lost already, with the sprint goal at risk.

C Raise it at the retrospective.

Useful for learning, but far too late to unblock the sprint.

D Go to the security lead; escalate if needed.

The leader removes a blocker outside the team's control, now.

THE SIGNAL

A blocker outside the team, threatening the goal: the leader removes it, today.

> A project manager has five open issues and time to work on only one or two today. One is blocking a critical path activity. The others are a formatting problem, a meeting-room clash, a query about expenses, and a minor tool licence renewal.
>
> The oldest is the expenses query.

Which issue should the project manager address first?

A The expenses query, because it is the oldest.

B The issue blocking the critical path activity.

C The formatting problem, because it is quickest to fix.

D Whichever issue was raised by the most senior person.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which issue should the project manager address first?

A The oldest.
Age is not impact. The expenses query delays nothing important.

B The critical path blocker.
Every day it stays open delays the whole project.

C The quickest.
Feels productive; changes nothing that matters.

D The most senior requester.
Priority comes from impact, not rank.

THE SIGNAL

Prioritise issues by impact on the goal or critical path. Not by age, ease or rank.

> A new project manager inherits an issue log with thirty open issues. Many are months old, most have no owner, and nobody is sure which are still real.
>
> Stakeholders have stopped reading it.

What should the project manager do?

A Archive the whole log and start a new one.

B Add any new issues to the existing log and carry on.

C Review each issue with the team: close the resolved ones, assign owners and dates, escalate stuck critical ones, and set a regular review.

D Report the thirty open issues to the sponsor as they stand.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Archive it and start again.

Some of those issues may still be real, and now forgotten.

B Carry on adding to it.

Adds to a log nobody trusts or reads.

C Review, close, assign, escalate, set a rhythm.

Restores a useful log and the reassessment the outline asks for.

D Report it as it stands.

Passes on noise; the sponsor cannot act on stale, ownerless items.

THE SIGNAL

A stale, ownerless issue log: clean it up with the team, then keep it alive with a regular review.

> A developer has been stuck on an integration problem for three days without telling anyone. When asked, she says she did not want to look incompetent in front of the team.
>
> The team's daily meetings have become brief status reports to the project leader.

What should the project leader do?

A Help her with the blocker now, and work with the team to make raising blockers early normal and safe.

B Remind her firmly that blockers must be reported within a day.

C Reassign the integration work to a more experienced developer.

D Add daily progress reports so hidden problems are caught.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project leader do?

A Help now; make raising blockers safe.
Clears this blocker and fixes why blockers stay hidden.

B A firm reminder.
Adds to the fear that caused the silence.

C Reassign the work.
Confirms her fear of looking incompetent.

D More progress reports.
More status reporting, when status meetings are part of the problem.

THE SIGNAL

Hidden blockers come from fear. Remove today's blocker, then remove the fear.

Planned response if it exists. **Workaround** if not. Remove what the team cannot.

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